

goal was to provide for my family, so I spent the majority of every day working. I missed a lot of magical moments when my kids were young. It was a huge sacrifice, and I like to think it paid off with the family dynasty I've been able to offer—but I know for a fact that Linda often felt like a single parent during those early years.

If you're a single parent, I want to say right now that I have tremendous respect for you. You are doing the most important job in the world, and you are doing it alone. Hats off to you for the incredible amount of time, effort and love you pour into your work every day.

You're not alone. According to Statistics Canada, single-parent households have been on the rise for the last four decades. In 2011, 16 percent of families were classified as "lone-parent families." Eight out of 10 times, the lone parent is female. Sadly, homes headed by a single mother are at a significant economic disadvantage compared to married couples and common-law partners. The difference in income is striking. In 2011, the median after-tax income for two-parent families with children was \$83,600, whereas the median after-tax income for female *lone*-parent families was \$39,900. This is tragic because it means the youngest members of society—children—suffer most. Only 5.9 percent of children being raised by two parents are living in low income. Compare that to 23 percent of children being raised by a single parent.

You may not be a typical single parent. Maybe your spouse passed away and you were forced into single parenthood against your will. Maybe you're married to a workaholic who's never around to help with the kids or the house. I don't know your personal situation or your relationship history. The one thing I do know is that if you're a single parent, the rules may be harder, but they do apply.

Money Mistake: *You Spoil Your Kids Out of Guilt*

The Fix: *Instill a Sense of Autonomy Instead*

When you're raising children alone, there is often a temptation to make up for the absence of the other parent. Not only is this